

Duke Nukem Forever

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It is hard to have a discussion about Duke Nukem Forever and not talk about the game's long and less than illustrious development history. This game was announced by 3D Realm almost immediately after the success of Duke Nukem 3D and its less popular sibling, Shadow Warrior. During the years following this announcement, Duke Nukem Forever had become something of a myth in the computer games circle, while some had simply dismissed the game as vaporware. One began to wonder if 'Forever' in the game's moniker was wishing the game's leads character longevity or was it simply a recognition of the time the game was going to take to be completed. Then sometime in 2009, financial woes forced 3D Realms to yield and the game's development was handed over to Gearbox Software by the Take Two Interactive, who had signed on as the game's publisher.

In Limbo

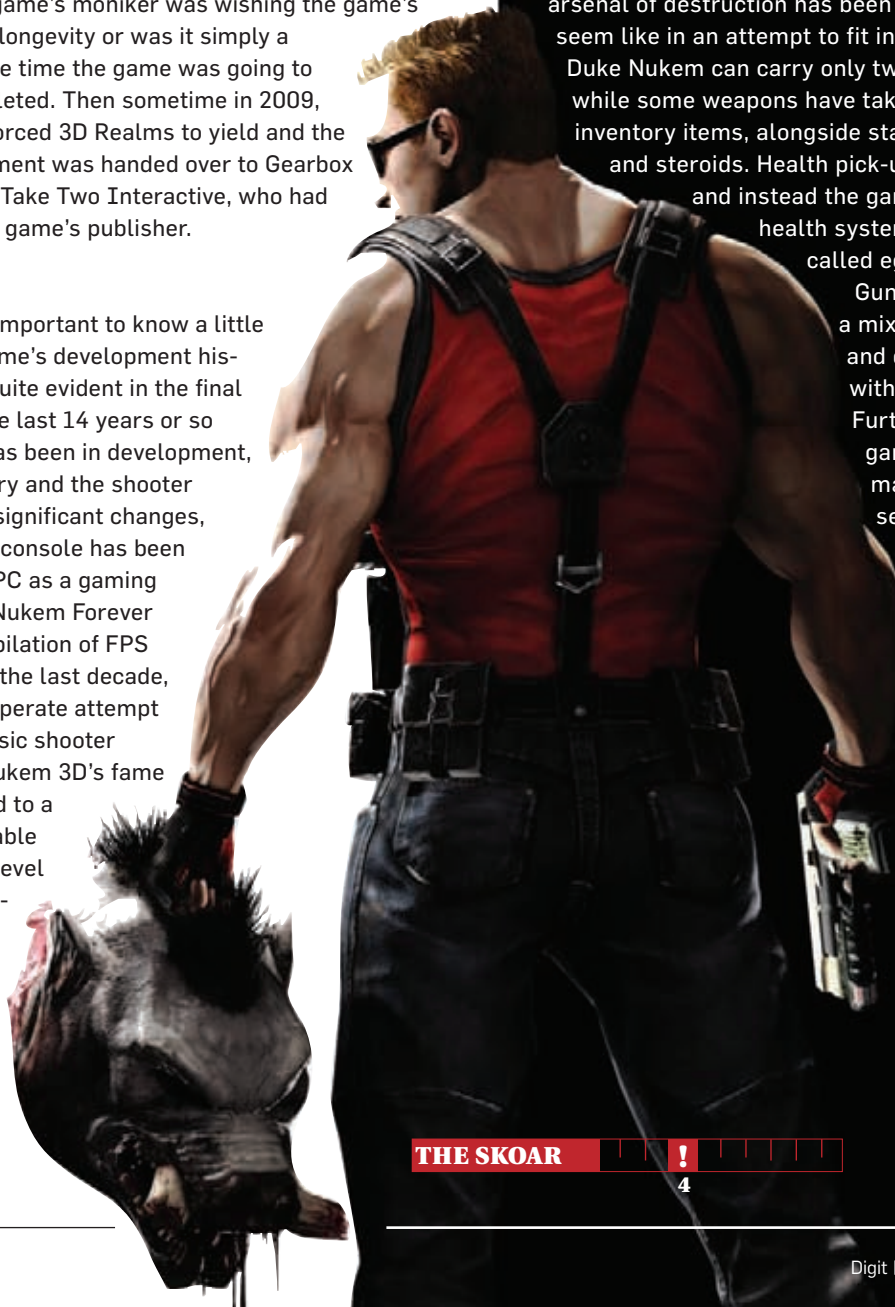
It is somewhat important to know a little bit about this game's development history, since it is quite evident in the final product. Over the last 14 years or so that the game has been in development, the game industry and the shooter genre has seen significant changes, especially since console has been overshadowing PC as a gaming platform. Duke Nukem Forever feels like a compilation of FPS Greatest Hits of the last decade, along with a desperate attempt to retain its classic shooter identity. Duke Nukem 3D's fame can be attributed to a mix of a memorable character, high-level of player interactions with the game-world and innovative weapon's design. In comparison, which may or may not be fair, Duke

Nukem Forever is a seriously underwhelming experience. The sequel has failed to find a respectable balance between the new and the old, and ultimately ending up in limbo.

The Duke and the King

This game picks-up after the events of Duke Nukem 3D, during a time when Duke is largely hailed as a hero for rescuing Earth from an alien invasion. Now, Duke Nukem has a palatial abode, twin female pop-stars as his personal 'aide' and his own casino. The effect this has had on Duke is that he now relies on his ego, instead of his health, to shrug-off enemy fire. On the other hand, his capacity to carry an arsenal of destruction has been significantly truncated. It seem like in an attempt to fit in with the console crowd, Duke Nukem can carry only two weapons at a time; while some weapons have taken the form of collectible inventory items, alongside stat boosting items like beer and steroids. Health pick-ups have been eliminated and instead the game employs regenerative health system, which in this case is called ego bar.

Gun battle set-pieces are a mixture of good, mediocre and down-right frustrating with spiking difficulty levels. Furthermore, for a shooter game, there are a bit too many annoying platforming sequences. Renegade attitude of Duke Nukem, along with trademark crass humor has found home in the sequel. However, depending on one's threshold for such things, some attempts at humor in this game may seem tasteless. Looking at Duke Nukem Forever as a game in itself, rather than a sequel, it comes out as a half-decent game. If you do feel like playing this game just to part of this industry's history, then we highly recommend doing it on the PC. ■



THE SKOAR

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